

- RAG Learning

3A.6 Comparative Approaches

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 3A: Comparative Politics — USA

Exam Tip: This topic is tested directly by **Section B** of the paper: one **compulsory** 12-mark comparative question (AO1 6 / AO2 6). It is the one topic on the route you cannot avoid, so it deserves more attention than a sixth of your revision time.

The three approaches are tools for *explaining* similarities and differences between the UK and US systems, not extra content to describe. The marks come from applying them.

Rational approach — explains behaviour by the calculations of individuals pursuing their own interests.

Cultural approach — explains behaviour by shared ideas, values, beliefs and group attachments.

Structural approach — explains behaviour by the institutions, rules and processes that shape and constrain action.

Comparative politics — the systematic comparison of political systems to explain their similarities and differences.

1. The three approaches

Approach	Asks	Typical explanation	Limitation
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Rational	What is in this actor's interest?	US legislators defy their party because re-election depends on a district and a primary electorate, not on the leadership	Takes preferences as given; struggles with behaviour that is not self-interested; risks unfalsifiability
Cultural	What do people in this society believe and value?	Americans accept judicial authority over contested questions; the British treat it as overreach	Risks circularity; struggles to explain change within one country over time
Structural	What do the rules permit, reward and prevent?	UK party discipline is strong because the executive is drawn from the legislature, so a government's survival and an MP's promotion both depend on supporting it	Cannot explain where institutions came from, or why identical rules produce different results in different societies

They are **complementary, not rival**: institutions set the field of play, culture determines what is thinkable within it, and individuals calculate given both. An answer relying on only one will mistake a feature of the design for a feature of the people, or the reverse.

2. Constitutional arrangements compared

	UK	USA
Form	Uncodified, unentrenched	Codified, entrenched
Amendment	Ordinary Act of Parliament	Two-thirds of Congress, three-quarters of states
Sovereignty	Parliamentary — legally undivided	Popular, expressed through a constitution binding all branches

Territorial	Unitary with devolution; powers rest on statute	Federal; the division is entrenched
Rights	HRA 1998 — an ordinary statute; declarations of incompatibility	Bill of Rights — entrenched; courts may strike down

Structural explanation: the UK's arrangements emerged incrementally without a founding moment; the US Constitution was written at one, by delegates bargaining between states that would not otherwise have united. **Cultural explanation:** American constitutional patriotism — a nation without a single ethnic identity using the Constitution as a focus of allegiance — gives the document and its interpreters standing no UK equivalent possesses.

3. The executives compared

	UK Prime Minister	US President
Selection	Leader of the party commanding Commons confidence	Separately elected via the Electoral College
Relationship to legislature	Fused — sits in and commands it	Separated — must bargain with it
Tenure	Insecure — removable by their own party at any time	Fixed four-year term; only impeachment removes, and never has
Legislative capacity	High with a majority — can pass a programme	Low under divided government; cannot introduce bills
Cabinet	Collective responsibility binds; senior colleagues can remove the PM	Advisory; the President is not bound by it

The formulation worth memorising: the PM is **more powerful domestically and less secure in office**; the President is **less able to legislate and cannot be removed by their own party**. Fusion

concentrates power and makes the leader dependent on the party; separation disperses power and makes the leader independent of it. That is a single structural cause producing both differences.

4. The judiciaries compared

	UK Supreme Court	US Supreme Court
Power over legislation	May interpret and declare incompatibility; may not strike down	May declare acts of Congress unconstitutional and void
Basis	Statute — CRA 2005, HRA 1998	Asserted in <i>Marbury</i> (1803)
Appointment	Independent selection commission	Presidential nomination, Senate confirmation — overtly political
Tenure	To retirement age	Life

Structural explanation (the stronger one): a codified entrenched constitution gives the US Court a higher law to enforce against Congress; parliamentary sovereignty leaves the UK Court interpreting statute it cannot override. **Cultural explanation:** differing attitudes to judicial authority — but this risks circularity, since Americans may accept judicial authority because their judges have long exercised it.

5. Electoral and party systems compared

	UK	USA
System	FPTP for Westminster; proportional systems in devolved bodies	FPTP for Congress; Electoral College for the presidency
Candidate selection	Local and national party	Primary voters

Party discipline	Strong — whips, patronage, confidence	Weaker, though rising with polarisation
Third parties	Fail nationally; succeed regionally (SNP)	Fail almost entirely; insurgents capture a major party instead
Campaign finance	Capped national spending; PPERA 2000	Spending is protected speech; Super PACs

Rational explanation of the discipline difference: in the UK the party controls selection, so loyalty is a precondition of a career; in the US primary voters control it, so defying the leadership carries little cost while cooperating with the other party may carry a great deal. Same type of actor, opposite incentives — which is rational explanation at its strongest, since it requires no assumption that legislators differ in character.

6. Pressure groups and civil rights compared

US groups have **more access points**: federalism creates fifty state governments, the separation of powers makes executive, both chambers and the courts independent routes, and judicial review makes litigation effective. UK groups must generally work on the government, because parliamentary sovereignty largely closes the judicial route and the executive controls the legislature.

On rights, the US entrenches them and gives courts the power to enforce against the legislature; the UK protects them by ordinary statute and political restraint. The trade-off is the same one that recurs across every comparison: entrenchment secures rights against majorities at the cost of handing contested questions to unelected judges.

7. Applying the approaches

Exam Tip: A Section B answer should **name the approach, apply it, and assess it**. For example: "The structural approach best explains stronger UK party discipline, because the executive is drawn from the legislature, so both a government's survival and an MP's

promotion depend on supporting it. A cultural explanation — British deference — is weaker, because it cannot explain why rebellion rates have risen sharply while the culture has not obviously changed." That sentence pattern earns AO1, AO2 and the evaluation in one paragraph.

Question	Best approach	Why
Why is UK party discipline stronger?	Structural / rational	Fusion and selection control create the incentives; no cultural assumption needed
Why do third parties fail in both?	Structural	Single-member plurality districts convert dispersed support into no seats in both systems
Why is the US judiciary more powerful?	Structural	A higher law to enforce; the cultural account risks circularity
Why do US legislators defy their party?	Rational	Re-election depends on a primary electorate, not the leadership
Why do Americans accept judicial authority?	Cultural	Constitutional patriotism — though partly a consequence of the structure

Quick recall

- Rational (interests) · cultural (values) · structural (institutions) — complementary, not rival
- Structural is usually the strongest, because the same actors behave differently under different rules
- Cultural risks circularity; rational takes preferences as given
- PM: more powerful domestically, less secure. President: less able to legislate, cannot be removed by their party
- UK Court declares incompatibility; US Court strikes down — because one has a higher law to enforce
- US pressure groups have more access points because federalism and separation create them

- Section B is compulsory and comparative — name the approach, apply it, assess it